

zon. It is rated to handle speeds of up to 300Mbps.

Another popular option is Netgear WN3000RP-200INS, which retails at ₹ 2070. Both these routers can be plugged into a wall socket for power while doing their magic of extending the reach of your Wi-Fi router.

Range extenders can also handle up to one wired connection. This is helpful to plug in devices like smart TVs or game consoles. When activated, you will see an additional hotspot in your list of Wi-Fi connections to choose from. In cases where you are in proximity to both routers, choose the stronger signal.

One problem that is stated online about Wi-Fi extenders is that, because these split the band between communication devices and the extender, devices end up getting lower speeds. A way to get out of this is to opt for better featured routers that enable one band to communicate with the router and another band to communicate with the devices. Netgear EX6100 has this feature, and Netgear markets it as FastLane technology.

Wireless data cards, or MiFi.

These data cards allow you to use a mobile network as a Wi-Fi access point for your devices. MiFi is the brand of these cards as sold by Novatel Wireless since 2009, which a lot of other brands have copied to sell their own products as MiFi.

The highest-rated option available is Huawei Power-Fi E8231 with 1366 ratings, giving it an average of 4.5 stars. Selling at ₹ 1673, it supports HSPA + 21.6Mbps downlink and HSUPA 5.76Mbps uplink, while up to ten devices can be connected to it. This device does not support 4G, though.

Second highest is D-Link DWR710 Lepetit selling at ₹ 1523, which shows as supporting 4G on its Amazon listing. According to D-Link website, this device has 3G downlink of up to 21Mbps and 3G uplink of up to 11.4Mbps.

In third place, there is iBall 21.0

Myth busted!

People tend to assume that media access control (MAC) addresses are hardwired to your hardware, but that is not the case. This means that, although many techies swear by MAC addresses filtering to keep their Wi-Fi networks secure, it may not really be the best option you can go for.

The reason is that, it is very easy to change your MAC address (learn how, at www.electronicshobby.com/macattack). What's more is that, the MAC address is broadcast when you use Wi-Fi, so it is easy for an attacker to sniff out Wi-Fi traffic and change their MAC address to an allowed one.

So what do you do? Encrypt your network with WPA2-PSK encryption and a strong passphrase.

MP-58 Wi-Fi ready Airway Data Card that costs ₹ 1200 with an average rating of 3.5 stars. It also comes with a 32GB microSD support as well as a free package of 5GB Cloud storage.

Wi-Fi antennae. The problem with a directional antenna is that if the range and coverage problem in your home is due to walls and other large obstacles, this device might not really make much of a difference. However, if the situation is such that only a certain corner of the house is suffering from 50 per cent Wi-Fi range, then it will suit your needs. ASUS WL-ANT-157 antenna is one option that costs ₹ 3300 and gives 7dBi gain towards the direction in which it is pointed.

On the other hand, if you are looking for an antenna with better gain, then one good example is super power supply Wi-Fi RP-SMA antenna. It is taller than 30 centimetres compared to the 12-centimetre stock antenna that comes with a normal router. You can get three of these 9dBi (decibels relative to isotropic) antennae at ₹ 2609, or a single 12dBi dual-band antenna for ₹ 1940.

Now that you are aware of routers that can satisfy your needs, whether it is a bare-minimum router like TL-WDR3600 or a high-end alien-looking RT-AC5300, we hope you will be able to enjoy your purchase. **EFY**

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